

Handout - *E. J. Lowe, “The Nature of Metaphysics”*

THE PROBLEM: What is Metaphysics, and Is It Possible?

Lowe opens by diagnosing a **confusion or misconception** about the nature and legitimacy of metaphysics. It is often misunderstood as:

- A kind of *mysticism or pseudoscience*.
- A second-order discipline relative to physics (as metaethics is to ethics).
- A speculative or obsolete mode of thought undermined by empirical science or relativism.

Lowe's project is **defensive and constructive**: he wants to **clarify what metaphysics is**, rebut key objections to its legitimacy, and articulate its **distinctive and necessary role** in human inquiry.

THE SOLUTION: Metaphysics as the Study of Reality as a Whole

Lowe defends a **traditional conception** of metaphysics:

Metaphysics is the non-empirical, rational investigation of the fundamental structure of reality as a whole.

He argues that this discipline is:

- **Ineliminable**: Even denying metaphysics requires metaphysical commitments.
 - **Interdisciplinary**: It adjudicates the boundaries and assumptions of other disciplines (e.g., physics, psychology, sociology).
 - **Universal**: It concerns *everything that exists*, not just things in space and time.
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I. What is Metaphysics?

Lowe clarifies the nature of metaphysics by distinguishing it from related fields:

- **Not mysticism** or magical thinking.
- **Not just a philosophy of physics**: While it overlaps with physics, metaphysics is not about the *methods* of physics, but rather its *foundations and assumptions*.
- The historical origin of the term comes from Aristotle's *Metaphysics*, which followed his *Physics* in canonical ordering, not in hierarchy or methodology.

Distinctive features of metaphysics:

- It investigates **entities both in space and time** (like physical objects) and **abstract entities** (like numbers, propositions, sets).
 - It addresses entities *not reducible to physical explanation*—such as mental states, social institutions, and rational agency.
 - It uses **a priori** reasoning—non-empirical, conceptual reflection—to explore **possibility, necessity, causation, identity**, etc.
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II. The Role of Metaphysics

Metaphysics as *arbiter of interdisciplinary disputes*:

- It mediates questions like whether psychology or sociology reduce to physics.
- Only metaphysics can address such “boundary questions,” because only metaphysics has a **completely unrestricted subject matter**.

“Metaphysics... is conceptually necessary as the intellectual backdrop for every other discipline” (p. 3).

III. Objections to Metaphysics and Lowe's Replies

1. Relativism (Cultural or Historical)

- **Objection:** Truth is culturally or historically relative; hence, a universalist metaphysics is impossible.
- **Lowe's Reply:**
 - This is itself a **metaphysical claim** (about the nature of truth and reality).
 - If relativism is true, it must be defended with arguments about what exists, how truth works—thus, metaphysics is unavoidable.

The attempt to eliminate metaphysics is *self-defeating* because it inevitably involves metaphysical assumptions.

2. Naturalized Epistemology (Quine, et al.)

- **Objection:** All knowledge must be explainable in terms of natural science (e.g., cognitive psychology, biology). Hence, metaphysics is suspect.
 - **Lowe's Reply:**
 - Naturalism can't explain its own cognitive foundation. If evolution makes metaphysical knowledge suspect, it equally undermines **scientific knowledge**.
 - The debate over what counts as "knowledge" is itself a **metaphysical debate** about epistemic possibility.
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3. Kantianism (Metaphysics as Structure of Thought)

- **Objection:** Metaphysics doesn't describe reality, but our *conceptual scheme* (Kant: metaphysical truths are about the structure of thought, not things-in-themselves).
 - **Lowe's Reply:**
 - The Kantian move itself presupposes metaphysical theses (e.g., that we cannot know mind-independent reality).
 - Thoughts themselves *are part of mind-independent reality* (they exist whether or not we reflect on them), so studying their content is still metaphysics in the traditional sense.
 - Moreover, metaphysical knowledge need not be **certain** or **infallible** to be genuine (cf. mathematics).
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IV. Metaphysics and Empirical Knowledge

Lowe draws a helpful analogy between **metaphysics** and **mathematics**:

- Both are concerned with **non-empirical** knowledge.
- But metaphysics differs from mathematics in that it concerns **contingent** as well as **necessary** structures of reality.

Key point:

Even contingent metaphysical truths must be **possible** truths, and **possibility** is not something that can be determined by empirical methods alone.

Thus, metaphysics plays the role of mapping the **space of ontological possibility**, even if empirical science helps tell us *which* possibilities are actual.

V. Possibility, Semantics, and Conceptual Analysis

Is possibility merely about language?

- Some philosophers argue that modal claims reduce to **semantic or conceptual truths** (e.g., “a bachelor can’t be married” is true because of what the words mean).
 - Lowe rejects this view:
 - Some possibilities (e.g., whether a person can jump 10 feet, or whether time travel is possible) are **not about language** but about **the nature of things**.
 - Concepts are useful insofar as they track real features of things. Adequate concepts **reflect** metaphysical structure, they do not constitute it.
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VI. Ontology and Categories

Metaphysics centers on ontology—the study of being.

- Inspired by Aristotle, Lowe frames metaphysics as the study of **being qua being**—what exists, in what ways, and how entities are categorized.
 - He offers a **hierarchical model** of ontological categories (Fig. 1.1, p. 16):
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TAKEAWAY

Lowe's defense of metaphysics relies on a central insight:

Metaphysical inquiry is **inescapable** because even attempts to deny or naturalize it **presuppose** metaphysical claims.

- **Relativists** make metaphysical claims about truth.
- **Naturalists** make metaphysical claims about what kinds of knowledge are possible.
- **Kantians** end up doing traditional metaphysics under a new label.

Metaphysics is thus not only possible—it is **unavoidable**. We are all metaphysicians, whether we acknowledge it or not.
